

Mailbox, shared mailbox, list, or group?

Six objects that look alike in the address book but behave very differently. Choose by what it needs to do: hold mail, send mail, share a workspace, or grant access.

Mailboxes Groups Admin note

Checked against Microsoft Learn, September 2026

 User mailbox One person's own mailbox, calendar and contacts, tied to their own sign-in. KEY FEATURES ✓ Personal inbox, calendar and contacts ✓ Signs in with their own account ✓ Can delegate Full Access or Send As to others ✓ Requires an Exchange Online license EXAMPLES john@company.com sarah@company.com Offboarding: convert before removing the license. Keep the account, block sign-in, and stay under 50 GB if unlicensed.	 Shared mailbox A common inbox that several people inside the organization monitor and reply from. KEY FEATURES ✓ Common inbox and shared calendar ✓ Full Access to open and manage items ✓ Send As or Send on Behalf to reply — Full Access alone can't send ✓ Delegate access is internal only; external senders can email it if allowed EXAMPLES support@company.com info@company.com Unlicensed up to 50 GB; delegates still need Exchange Online. Over 50 GB needs Plan 2. Archive or hold: Plan 2, or Plan 1 + Archiving. Block sign-in.	 Distribution list Sends one message to many recipients. Nothing is stored — there's no mailbox behind it. KEY FEATURES ✓ Fans email out to every member ✓ Can accept external senders if enabled ✓ No mailbox, calendar or files ✓ Dynamic version builds membership from user attributes EXAMPLES all-staff@company.com sales@company.com Microsoft 365 Groups can't be members of a distribution group. Only eligible cloud-managed, simple, non-nested groups can be upgraded.	 Microsoft 365 Group A shared workspace for a team: one membership list drives mail, files, calendar and planning. KEY FEATURES ✓ Group mailbox and calendar ✓ SharePoint site for shared files ✓ Planner, OneNote and Stream ✓ Guests and dynamic membership supported EXAMPLES project-team@company.com marketing@company.com Every team is backed by a Microsoft 365 Group. Create a new one with the team, or connect an eligible existing group.	 Security group Controls who gets access, licenses and policies. It has no email address. KEY FEATURES ✓ Access to SharePoint, apps and resources ✓ Group-based licensing, Conditional Access and Intune targeting ✓ Dynamic membership in Entra ID ✓ Can hold users, devices, service principals and other groups EXAMPLES SG-M365-Admins SG-Intune-Pilot A cloud security group can't be mail-enabled later. If it needs email, create a mail-enabled security group instead.	 Mail-enabled security group Grants access to resources and also receives email for the same members. KEY FEATURES ✓ Access control plus an email address ✓ Created and managed in Exchange ✓ Read-only in Entra ID and Microsoft Graph ✓ No dynamic membership EXAMPLES finance-team@company.com hr-staff@company.com Use only when you truly need both. For licensing and Intune, a plain security group is easier to manage.
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Quick rule

One person
→ User mailbox

One team, one inbox
→ Shared mailbox

One message, many people
→ Distribution list

Team collaboration
→ Microsoft 365 Group

Access, licenses, policy
→ Security group

Access plus email
→ Mail-enabled SG